

The Second COMING

Rajasekhara Reddy's impressive showing is a tribute to his organisational skills. He now has the mandate to streamline his party, shed the deadwood and push development.

A PRABHAKAR RAO



REDDY AFTER HIS HUGE VICTORY WHICH GIVES HIM GREATER LEEWAY

| By Amarnath K. Menon |

When Telugu Desam Party (TDP) president N. Chandrababu Naidu rose to speak for the first time as the leader of the Opposition in the last legislative assembly in 2004, he listed his achievements during his 'nine years' as chief minister. Incumbent Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy interjected with a correction, saying it was actually eight years, eight months and 13 days. Although minor, it displayed Reddy's competitive reflexes. That, along with his political grit and determination helped him become the first Congress chief minister to complete a full five-year term and achieve his ambition of beating Naidu's record as the longest-serving chief minister of Andhra Pradesh.

"This is a historic win for my party," declared Reddy and there was no hyperbole involved. Saturday's result (see graph) is a triumph for the Congress. He has destroyed a 30-year-old jinx that has prevented the

Andhra Pradesh Total Seats 294

PARTY	SEATS 2009	SEATS 2004	Vote Share %
CONG	157	185	38.62
TDP	92	47	37.27
TRS	10	26	6.68
OTHERS	23	36	15.98

Others: CPI, CPI(M), PRP, etc. A few results were still awaited.

Congress from winning successive elections as the ruling party in the state. The party has won 29 fewer seats than it did in 2004 but what makes it satisfying for Reddy is that the Congress has done it without depending on an electoral ally—a strategy that his main rival Naidu has steadfastly banked on in 1999 and 2004. Naidu fell back on the same electoral arithmetic to rope in the CPI